city. She would check signal timings/errors and ensure that corrections were carried out on the spot. She would help push broken-down vehicles that were blocking the roads for the want of cranes. As the police department had none, she hired all the available cranes in the city to patrol the roads and cart away the wrongly parked vehicles, whomsoever it may belong to; she also spot-fined the errant ones and spared no one, whatever be their status. All these moves sent shivers down the spines of all VIPs' drivers. They scurried into parking lots, apprehending that 'Crane Bedi may come'.

She would communicate with her staff on duty – from the constable to the higher ranks – and understand from them the areas where improvements were needed. She would share her observations through wireless messages. She constantly learnt from her ground staff and shared her acquired knowledge with all the others, keeping in mind the larger growth of the organization. She rewarded her staff liberally and punished most sparingly. Due to her presence on the ground daily, the attendance and punctuality were cent per cent visible.

It became a common sight for the Delhi people to see Kiran Bedi personally on the road every day, anytime, clearing traffic bottlenecks or pointing out irregularities in specific cases. A woman's voice coming over the loudspeaker made an impression upon the motorists and the pedestrians that a male voice could not have done. It was the first time in the history of city traffic management of the country that one saw such intervention and participation at the field level. It was both education and enforcement at the same time. People loved it and welcomed it and they too joined in. They hailed her wherever she went. Her road patrolling was removing long-entrenched obstructions and also changing people's habits and mindsets. She was fair and fearless in her approach to diverse challenges. During that period, Kiran put in 19 hours of non-stop work each day. She returned home exhausted. After dinner, while she lay in bed, her mother and her domestic help massaged her vocal cords (which were under a lot of strain due to overuse) to revitalize them. And in the morning she would get up, fresh again, to put in the maximum efforts once again.

After performing her morning field duties, Kiran would reach her office by noon to hold interdepartmental as well as intradepartmental meetings, return calls and meet visitors. There was no paper work at all during this time. The entire focus was on issues, decisions and time-bound implementation of such decisions on the ground. And all knew there was no getting away from the daily rough and tumble on the roads of Delhi. Those days the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) was busy with the construction of roads and flyovers; the Delhi Electric Supply Undertaking (DESU) was concerned with the erection of electric light poles and laying of cables; and the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) was responsible for the land being used for the construction of roads and sanctioning of many projects. Over and above these bodies there was a professional consultant, D. Sanyal, from the National Transportation, Planning and Research Centre (NATPAC) who was coordinating all matters pertaining to traffic engineering, transportation planning and traffic management. Kiran felt that all these activities could not be effectively planned and executed by merely holding drawing-room meetings and hence suggested that the actual behaviour patterns of the motorists could be seen and verified only on the roads. Everyone agreed. Consequently, representatives from all the aforementioned bodies formed a group.

This group requisitioned a chartered bus to move from point to point; on-the-spot decisions were taken and corrections made wherever required. No ego clashes; no bickering. All steps were taken in the larger interest, by seeing, listening, understanding and deciding collectively. In this way this 'government on wheels' acted as a homogeneous team and the usual interdepartmental squabbles and lack of coordination were eliminated. Most of all, there were no delays for there was no 'paper mountain' and no finger pointing.